

immediately. Cramping later in pregnancy that isn't accompanied by bleeding is probably nothing to worry about, but again mention it to your doctor.

» What can I do?

Most cramping is perfectly benign, but because very occasionally it is a symptom of something more significant it's always important to alert your doctor. Rest as much as you can. A warm bath can help to soothe aching, stretched, and displaced muscles and ligaments.

Restless legs

» What, when, and how often?

A tingling, creepy-crawly sensation in your legs, often when you're lying down or trying to sleep, restless legs affects up to 25 percent of pregnant women in the US and is most commonly reported in the third trimester of pregnancy. It's debilitating because it makes you feel like you want to move around all the time, even when you're trying to sleep.

» What causes it?

No one is really sure why pregnant women are more prone to restless leg syndrome, but it could be that there is increased circulation through the veins, pregnancy weight gain, low iron levels, or it may be a simple side effect of increased hormone levels. Studies indicate that it tends to run in families.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

As long as the condition is not related to an iron deficiency (see above), restless legs will pose no harm to you or your baby, aside from making you feel tired if it's hampering your sleep.

» What can I do?

Firstly, ask your doctor to check your iron levels. Do everything you can to encourage sleep—avoid eating too late at night, exercise gently (appropriately for your stage in pregnancy), and treat yourself to a soporific warm bath before bedtime. Walking around can cause temporary relief, as can giving your legs a quick rub.

Varicose veins and vulval varicosities

» What, when, and how often?

Varicose veins are enlarged veins that can develop in the legs and around the vulval area. They can look unsightly.

» What causes them?

During pregnancy the expanding uterus puts pressure on veins in the pelvis. This leads to increased pressure in the legs and vulval area, making varicose veins and vulval varicosities more likely to form (see p.120).

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Varicose veins can become uncomfortable and itchy in the later stages of pregnancy, but they aren't dangerous.

Back pain and sciatica

» What, when, and how often?

Most pregnant women experience some dull aching around their lower back during pregnancy. If that pain becomes sharp or shooting it may be sciatica—especially if it runs down the buttocks and backs of the legs, too (or more often down one leg). You are most likely to experience it during your third trimester, when your uterus is expanding into your abdomen and your baby is growing rapidly.

» What causes them?

Lower back pain is commonly caused by the shifting center of gravity as your baby grows and your uterus expands, causing you to stand and walk awkwardly in order to correct your balance. The loosening in your ligaments during pregnancy can also put strain on your back—all thanks to hormonal changes. Sciatica is a specific condition caused when there is compression on your sciatic nerve, which runs from your lower back down your legs. The compression may be the result of your shifting center of gravity, whereby other muscles in your lower back contract to keep you upright and in doing so squeeze the nerve. Or it may be specifically the baby's position in later pregnancy—when your baby's head descends into your pelvis it can press on the nerve. Weight gain and your expanding uterus are also common culprits.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

There is no specific danger to your baby from lower back pain or sciatica—the effects are really only on your own well-being and often your mood. Living in constant pain can be debilitating.

Sciatic nerve The main nerve leading to the legs and feet.

Sciatica This artwork shows the path of the nerve and the path of the pain resulting from compression of nerve at the pelvis.



» What can I do?

Kegel exercises (see p.67) and also swimming can help to strengthen and support your lower back, relieving the pain on the nerve. Although it's good not to let your lower back stiffen up, periods of rest when you've taken the weight off your feet will relieve pressure pain. You can try a hot compress on the sore part of your back. Ask your partner to give you a gentle lower back massage. Tell your doctor that you're suffering so that he or she can keep an eye on things. If you are in severe pain you might be referred to an obstetric physical therapist. Always consult your doctor before taking anything to ease your discomfort.

Varicosities in the vagina or vulval area won't rupture during birth or pose any other problems.

» What can I do?

Tell your doctor if you notice that you have developed a varicose vein. Wear pregnancy support hose or support underwear that a doctor can prescribe.

Foot problems

» What, when, and how often?

Many pregnant women suffer from aching arches and cramp in their feet. Swollen ankles and feet are another common pregnancy issue.

» What causes them?

Weight gain can put pressure on the arches of your feet, while using the muscles in your feet to correct your balance is also a cause of aching. Your extremities, including your

feet, are particularly prone to the problems associated with increased fluid in your system, which can cause edema, the medical name for fluid retention (see p.134).

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

For the health of your baby nothing at all, but foot pain and swollen ankles can make walking around fairly debilitating. If your feet and ankles swell excessively or very suddenly, let your doctor know.

» What can I do?

Take the weight off your feet as much as you can, raising your feet above your hips to help disperse any excess fluid. Keep your feet moving, even when you are sitting. Turning your feet at the ankle, first in one direction and then in the other can help to relieve pain and swelling. Although it may seem counterintuitive, drinking plenty of fluid will help to flush excess from your system. Try to gain weight slowly and wear comfortable footwear with good support.